Name _____ Date _____ Period _____

Annotation directions

1. Highlight in **pink** when Odysseus is acting like a hero or leader.
2. Circle the major events.
3. Make a ★ where you are clarifying, adding detail, or explaining. Then explain in writing in the margin.

from

The Odyssey

An Epic Poem by **Homer**

Translated by **Robert Fitzgerald**

The Lotus Eaters (from Book 9)

Odysseus is telling King Alcinous the story of his journey home from Troy. After the raid on the Cicones, where 72 of his men died, his ships set sail again for Ithaca.

"I might have made it safely home, that time, but as I came round Malea[1] the current took me out to sea, and from the north a fresh gale drove me on, past Cythera.[2] Nine days I drifted on the teeming sea before dangerous high winds. Upon the tenth we came to the coastline of the Lotus Eaters, who live upon that flower. We landed there to take on water.

1. **Malea** a cape at the southern tip of Greece.
2. **Cythera** an island off that cape.

All ships' companies mustered alongside for
the mid-day meal. Then I sent out two
picked men and a runner to learn what race of
men that land sustained. They fell in, soon
enough, with Lotus Eaters, who showed no
will to do us harm, only offering the sweet
Lotus to our friends— but those who ate
this honeyed plant, the Lotus, never cared to
report, not to return:
they longed to stay forever, browsing on that
native bloom, forgetful of their homeland. I
drove them, all three wailing, to the ships,
tied them down under their rowing benches,
and called the rest: 'All hands aboard; come,
clear the beach and no one taste the Lotus, or
you lose your hope of home.' Filing in to their
places by the rowlocks my oarsmen
dipped their long oars in the surf, and we
moved out again on our sea faring."